

If you want to follow in Erin's footsteps, a good starting point is to look for a property that needs paint, new bathroom vanities, and a yard makeover. You should stay away from anything too crazy (like knocking down walls, unless you're into that sort of thing), but don't underestimate what a little elbow grease can accomplish.

Even if you're about as handy as a cactus wearing a toolbelt, the internet is positively brimming with step-by-step tutorials. All the big-box home improvement stores offer classes on various home improvement skills that you can learn using *their* equipment and supplies. YouTube has a video for every repair under the sun. If all else fails—or if you're an old soul—physical, real-life libraries have reference books filled with step-by-step illustrations and instructions.

If you're willing to take on a little more work, certain projects will get you more bang for your buck. As fun as it might be to add a home theater in the basement, some projects cost more than they will recoup with the home's resale value. Most often, the best value-add renovations are:

- **Bathroom remodel.** On average, a bathroom remodel costs about \$10,000, depending on how fancy you want to get. With some clever DIY work, you might be able to pull off a budget of \$5,000 for a smaller bathroom.
- **Kitchen remodel.** Though even a minor kitchen remodel rings in at a hefty \$20,000, it's one of the universal ways to add value to a home. Who wouldn't want new countertops, shiny appliances, and those fancy soft-closing drawers? Depending on how ugly the kitchen is before remodeling, this project might be a no-brainer to add massive value to the home.
- **Adding square footage.** This is more costly and labor-intensive, but by adding square footage to a home—by, for example, constructing a bedroom in the attic or adding a bathroom in the basement—you instantly jack up the home's value. A two-bedroom, two-bathroom house is worth a lot less than a three-bedroom, three-bathroom house, no doubt about it. Note that these features must conform to certain laws to be considered “real” bedrooms and bathrooms, however, which is key to recouping the cost of the project.